

Historical Research on Tongyuanfang: Its History and Architectural Restoration

Compiled by Rain

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Chapter 1: The Historical Status and Research Value of Tongyuanfang, Xi'an

1.1 Geographical Location, Historical Status, and Functional Transformation

The Tongyuanfang Catholic Church is located on the north section of Zheng Street, Tongyuan Subdistrict, Gaoling District, Xi'an City, Shaanxi Province, situated in the core area of the Guanzhong Plain—the heartland of the Wei River basin in the central Shaanxi plain. It is approximately 40 kilometers due north of downtown Xi'an (Bell Tower) and about 4 kilometers from Gaoling District town. Its special geographical location made it historically an important hub connecting Xi'an Prefecture with other dioceses in the Northwest. The church was listed as a key cultural relics protection unit of Shaanxi Province in the fifth batch in 2008.

The Tongyuanfang Catholic Church was founded by the Italian Franciscans [1] in the 50th year of the Kangxi reign of the Qing Dynasty (1711), initially serving as a local missionary outpost. However, with the expansion of Catholicism in the Northwest region, since the establishment of the Apostolic Vicariate of Shaansi in 1844, the Tongyuanfang Church became the Cathedral of St. Francis, the residence of the first bishop, and the highest administrative and missionary institution established by the Catholic Church in Northwest China at that time. This transformation marked Tongyuanfang's evolution from a local church to a regional power center, officially becoming the center of church administration, education, culture, and religious life for the entire Northwest region. As the cathedral of the Apostolic Vicariate (Vicariatus Apostolicus) [2], it was directly under the Congregation for the Evangelization of Peoples of the Vatican [3]. This meant its administrative level was extremely high; the bishop (Apostolic Vicar) was directly appointed by the Pope and reported

to the Pope and the Congregation, enjoying great independence and authority. Therefore, Tongyuan Church was the direct executive center and hub of the Holy See in the Northwest region for implementing missionary strategies.

Around the cathedral, the church established a complete and self-sufficient church system and community facilities, including:

- Cathedral: The most core building, used for formal masses presided over by the bishop and major religious ceremonies.
- Bishop's Residence/Bishop's House: The residence for the daily life, office work, and diocesan administrative affairs of the Apostolic Vicar (Bishop). This is an essential facility for the cathedral.
- Convent/Nunnery: A place for nuns to live and practice, and responsible for operating orphanages, schools, or clinics and other charitable institutions.
- Minor Seminary: The base for training local clergy.
- Orphanage: Demonstrates charitable functions and expands social influence.

These institutions made Tongyuanfang form a powerful and stable social entity, praised by contemporaries as the 'Shaanxi General Church.' In addition, the Sino-Western architectural style presented by the buildings themselves is also precious material evidence of the Catholic Church's localization process in China.

1.2 Religious Origins and the 'Accommodation' Strategy

The beginning of the Tongyuanfang Church is closely connected with the pioneering work of Jesuit missionaries such as Alfonso Vagnoni [4], who were among the earliest Catholic missionaries to enter China. It is the earliest result of Matteo Ricci's 'Accommodation Policy' (Accommodation Policy) in the inland areas of Northwest China.

As early as around 1620 (the Tianqi era of the Ming Dynasty), Vagnoni was already preaching in the Gaoling area and established the first Catholic community in Shaanxi. This early introduction made the faith foundation of Tongyuanfang directly inherit the 'scholarly evangelization' tradition represented by Matteo Ricci, establishing its position as a 'cradle' in the history of Catholicism in the Northwest. In the early Qing Dynasty, Tongyuanfang was already the most concentrated and active Catholic community in Shaanxi and even the entire

Northwest region. Its history predates many later dioceses, becoming the veritable 'birthplace' and 'ancient model' of Catholicism in the Northwest.

This early and stable community formation provided a deep mass foundation and faith base for Tongyuanfang's later development into a vicariate center.

1.3 Reconstruction and the Unique Historicity of Architectural Heritage

Tongyuanfang suffered devastating damage in the 'Boxer Indemnity Church Persecution' of 1900 [5], but its subsequent reconstruction endowed the existing architectural complex with unique historical continuity and architectural significance. As the Catholic faith center of the Northwest, Tongyuanfang became a core target during the Boxer Rebellion's 'Support the Qing, Destroy the Foreigners' movement. In July 1900, thousands of Boxers and Qing troops jointly besieged the compound. This resulted in: complete material destruction: the Cathedral of St. Francis, the monastery, the printing house, and other carefully constructed supporting buildings were all destroyed. The community faced disintegration: hundreds of believers were martyred, many families perished together, and surviving believers were forced to flee in all directions.

With the signing of the humiliating Boxer Protocol, the church used the indemnity payments to launch an unprecedented reconstruction project. The reconstruction not only aimed to restore the former grand scale but also incorporated characteristics of the early 20th century and new construction techniques in architectural form and artistic decoration. Therefore, the existing Tongyuanfang architectural complex: first, retains the traditional spatial layout (such as central axis symmetry and courtyard organization). Second, it displays distinctive characteristics of the era (such as decorative details influenced by Western Neoclassicism).

This special experience of 'destruction and rebirth' makes Tongyuanfang an important 'living fossil' for studying the collision of Chinese and Western cultures in modern China, the resilience of religious faith, and community reconstruction.

1.4 Current Status and Core Research Value of the Tongyuanfang Community Architectural Complex

As a Franciscan church, Tongyuanfang Catholic Church is still in use today. Successive bishops have also been stationed here, continuing to manage diocesan affairs, which fully demonstrates its continuous religious function and historical continuity within the Northwest

Catholic network. At its peak, the architectural complex was grand in scale, a fully functional religious urban complex. Despite experiencing wars and changes of eras, four core heritage buildings remain today, including: the Cathedral, the Minor Seminary, the Convent, and the Orphanage. These four buildings are not only material carriers of the fusion of Chinese and Western architectural techniques but also the soul and core of the unique community form around them.

The Tongyuanfang community is a unique settlement. This unique community form, through long-term historical accumulation, has accumulated rich living cultural heritage, including mutual assistance networks bonded by faith, unique festival rituals, and oral history fused with Guanzhong local customs. Therefore, the Tongyuanfang Catholic Church and its existing architectural complex are not only important historical relics but also a living social history sample. The continuation of its functions and the uniqueness of its community constitute its irreplaceable value for cultural diversity. Research on the Tongyuanfang church architectural complex has three mutually supporting dimensions: historical, cultural, and architectural history.

1.4.1 Historical and Regional Cultural Value

Key witness to inland exchange: As the landmark architectural complex where Catholicism was introduced to the inland of Northwest China in the early 18th century, it was established by Italian missionaries and long served as the general church of the Northwest diocese. It was the hub where Sino-Western religious and cultural exchanges unfolded in the inland heartland.

Microcosm of international influence: The historical record that 'mail from overseas could reach here just by writing 'Tongyuan, China' vividly confirms its former widespread reputation in international exchanges. It is a rare case for studying China's modern inland opening to the outside world and cross-cultural communication.

1.4.2 Social History, Cultural Diversity, and Living Community Value

The Tongyuanfang Catholic Church architectural complex is not only a material carrier of history but also the soul and core of the unique religious town community around it. From the perspective of cultural fusion and social history, its value lies in the following aspects:

1. Unique community form and cultural heritage: Tongyuanfang is a settlement centered around the church with a long history. Its unique community form is not merely an

administrative division but is constructed by shared faith, intergenerational marital family relationships, and unique social division of labor. This 'Christian community' model, through long-term historical accumulation, has accumulated rich cultural heritage, including:

2. Intangible cultural heritage: Unique mass rituals, festival activities (such as the 'Help of Christians' feast day), wedding and funeral customs, and oral history and religious songs fused with local Guanzhong culture.

3. Living conditions: A mutual assistance system and moral norms bonded by religious faith have been formed within the community, passed down through generations, becoming a living sample for studying the living conditions and identity construction of religious communities in inland areas.

4. Materialization of cultural diversity and adaptation strategies: The church's architectural form, layout, decorative style, and functional settings clearly reflect the cultural adaptation strategies of Catholicism in China. More importantly, the community residents' daily practice of doctrines and customs reflects the deep adjustment and fusion between religious faith and Guanzhong local traditional culture, making it a rare community with high cultural diversity in China's inland areas.

5. Microcosm of social change: Although the general church has been moved to Xi'an, Tongyuanfang continues its religious function as a Franciscan church to this day. This continuous religious practice provides an important living social history sample for studying the impact of modern social changes and religious policy evolution on grassroots believer community forms and living conditions.

1.4.3 Architectural History and Construction Technique Value

The most complete architectural group sample: It is the most complete in scale and most representative in form among the existing Catholic architectural groups in Shaanxi Province.

Typical example of localization techniques: The four buildings fuse Chinese traditional wooden beam structures, barrel tile roofs with Western arched doors and windows, pilasters, and vaulted arches. In construction, Tongyuanfang Church often uses local techniques to simulate the visual effects of Western Baroque/Neoclassicism, forming a unique construction vocabulary of 'similar in form but not in reality.' This phenomenon is the product of the adjustment of Western church functional requirements to the Chinese traditional construction

system, providing precious physical specimens for studying architectural 'localization' in inland areas.

1.5 Research Gaps, Realistic Challenges, and Report Objectives

1.5.1 Research Imbalance and Industrialization Impact

Currently, academic attention has long been concentrated on coastal areas and political centers, leading to the long-term neglect of the Tongyuanfang case in the inland Northwest. This research imbalance obscures Tongyuanfang's unique value in the history of Catholicism in the Northwest, the mechanism of architectural form evolution, and the interaction between inland religious communities and modern industrialization.

A more severe realistic challenge is that Tongyuanfang is facing systematic impact from the surrounding rapid industrialization process. The Gaoling District of Xi'an City where Tongyuanfang is located is an important component of the Economic and Technological Development Zone. The architectural complex has been systematically and cluster-wise surrounded by large automobile manufacturing enterprises such as Shaanxi Automobile Group, new materials industrial parks, and logistics parks. This industrial wave not only changed the historical environment but also led to:

1. Community structure changes: The traditional agricultural economy model of the native believer community was replaced, young people migrated for work or to work in factories, leading to aging and empty-nesting of the permanent population. This industrial wave not only changed the physical landscape but also triggered profound changes in community structure and population composition. The traditional agricultural economy model was completely replaced, and the native, intergenerational believer community faced disintegration. A large number of young people entered factory work or moved to cities, leading to increased aging and empty-nesting of the permanent population. Although the regional total population increased due to the influx of migrant workers, the stable community network bonded by deep faith and blood ties is loosening. Tongyuanfang is at risk of degenerating from an absolute center of faith life into a cultural 'isolated island' of the community. Meanwhile, the stable community network bonded by deep faith is loosening, and Tongyuanfang faces the risk of degenerating from a faith center into a community cultural 'isolated island.'

In the face of such systematic impact, it is imperative to launch emergency collection work for historical materials and community memory. As the older generation of native residents passes away, their personally experienced details of community life, orally transmitted memories about the 'Boxer Indemnity Church Persecution,' and practical knowledge of traditional religious rituals will all disappear with them. Therefore, systematically conducting oral history interviews and comprehensively collecting audiovisual, documentary, and physical materials is no longer just an academic research project but a cultural rescue project racing against time. This concerns whether a complete and three-dimensional historical archive of Tongyuanfang can be preserved for the future, so that it does not lose its most core soul and identity in the encirclement of industrial civilization.

1.5.2 Emergency Work and Report Objectives

Facing the risk of cultural memory disappearing, launching emergency collection work for historical materials and community memory is imminent. Systematically conducting oral history interviews and comprehensively collecting audiovisual, documentary, and physical materials has risen to a cultural rescue project racing against time. Based on this, this book aims to:

1. Construct a diachronic context: Systematically sort out the historical development of Tongyuanfang since the late Ming Dynasty, deeply analyze its evolution from a grassroots missionary outpost to a regional general church and the core driving forces behind this process.
2. Analyze cultural fusion characteristics: Focus on examining the Sino-Western cultural fusion characteristics presented by its architectural complex in spatial layout, construction techniques, and decorative arts, establishing a correspondence between material form and cultural adaptation.
3. Re-evaluate historical contributions: Reassess its unique contributions in building the Northwest Catholic network, promoting faith localization, and in Sino-Western cultural interactions, in order to compensate for deficiencies in related research fields.

1.5.3 Argumentation Framework and Research Innovation Value

This book establishes a three-layer argumentation framework of 'historical context - architectural form - social environment,' aiming to conduct structured research:

1. Historical dimension: Construct a diachronic development context through documents.
2. Material dimension: Use architectural history methods to analyze cultural fusion in space and techniques.
3. Environmental dimension: Through field research, construct an interaction model between environmental change and cultural heritage.

This research model can be replicated for religious architectural heritage research in other inland areas, promoting the elevation of research in this field from case description to theoretical construction, with significant methodological innovation value. The research results will provide theoretical support and decision-making basis for cultural heritage protection in rapidly industrializing areas, highlighting its major realistic urgency and practical value.

In the contemporary context of accelerated industrialization, the research's realistic urgency is further highlighted. The current situation of the 'Jingwei New City' industrial area where Tongyuanfang is located represents the universal predicament faced by numerous cultural heritages in China. By systematically recording the preservation status of its architectural complex and deeply analyzing the impact mechanism of industrial expansion on the historical environment, the research results will provide important theoretical references for cultural heritage protection in China's rapid urbanization process, and play a positive role in promoting the construction of a cultural heritage protection system with Chinese characteristics.

Chapter 2: Historical Evolution and Community Characteristics Research on Tongyuanfang

2.1. Chronological Basis and Period Overview

For a region with complex history and diverse functions like Tongyuanfang, periodization is the logical starting point of research and a necessary means to achieve in-depth analysis. Historical evolution is often continuous and complex. Periodization, by identifying key turning points (Turning Points), can divide the long history into several relatively stable and distinctly characterized stages. This not only provides a clear time coordinate system for the

entire research, elevating historical narration from simple chronology to developmental history with internal logical connections, but also helps reveal fundamental changes in function, architectural form, and community ecology at different stages. Periodization will guide our authenticity assessment of architectural remains from specific periods, serving the practice of architectural restoration and heritage protection.

2.1.1. Core Chronological Basis

The historical evolution and architectural development of Tongyuanfang are not isolated linear processes but are deeply integrated with macro Catholic missionary history and modern Chinese social change. This book aims to establish four clear and turning-point historical development stages through examining three elements: Tongyuanfang's religious administrative status, architectural complex morphology, and external social environmental impact. The periodization of this book is mainly based on the following three core changes:

1. Major changes in religious administrative status: The establishment of Tongyuanfang as the general church, the bishop's residency, and the eventual transfer of the general church.
2. Morphological transformation of the architectural complex (construction and fortification): Large-scale construction of churches, building of city walls (fortification), and perfection of functional buildings (such as convents, seminaries).
3. Huge impact from external social environment: The collapse of late Qing anti-Christian policies, social crises such as the Muslim Uprising and famine, and modern warlord 混战.

2.1.2. Period Overview

This chapter aims to establish four clear and turning-point historical development stages through examining three elements: Tongyuanfang's religious administrative status, architectural complex morphology, and external social environmental impact.

1. Changes: Establishing and Transferring Core Status

Periodization takes Tongyuanfang's administrative level changes in the Shaanxi Catholic Diocese as the primary basis. The key nodes of Tongyuanfang's history revolve around its status as the 'General Church':

Turning Point 1: 1845 (Bishop Fosco's appointment). This year marks the loosening of the Qing government's anti-Christian policy (1844) and the Roman Curia's formal appointment of Fosco as Bishop of Shaanxi. Tongyuanfang was officially selected as the general church of the Shaanxi Diocese. This is the origin of Tongyuanfang's qualitative change from a 'local gathering point' to the 'Northwest Church Center.'

Turning Point 2: 1932 (Transfer of General Church). Bishop Tissot de Chardins formally moved the general church to Xi'an. Subsequently, the Vatican divided the Guanzhong Diocese into five dioceses, with Gaoling under the jurisdiction of the Sanyuan Diocese. Although the Sanyuan bishop was stationed in Gaoling, its administrative affiliation and symbolic status had fundamentally shifted. This node marks the end of Tongyuanfang's era as a regional administrative center and its entry into the functional convent era.

2. Morphological transformation of the architectural complex: From simple to fortified, then to fully functional

Construction activities recorded the church's expansion trajectory and its survival strategies in response to the external environment. Large-scale construction and morphological transformation constitute important visual and physical chronological evidence:

Turning Point 3: 1901 (Death of Pagnucci, fortification completed). During this period, the church's construction activities experienced a leap from nothing to something. Vagnoni presided over the construction of the grand Gothic cathedral, and Pagnucci organized the construction of defensive walls (the famous Tongyuanfang walls) and perfected functional buildings such as the seminary, convent, and orphanage. Before Pagnucci's death in 1901, Tongyuanfang had formed a military-religious complex with 'soaring churches and surrounding walls,' with complete functions. The physical form known as the 'Little Rome of the East' was fully established. This form, in the social turmoil of the late Qing and early Republic, provided the church with the material foundation for survival and expansion.

3. Huge impact from external social environment: Changes in survival strategies

Sudden changes in the social environment profoundly influenced the church's survival strategies and development dynamics, becoming soft evidence for dividing historical stages:

Turning Point 4: 1902 (Internal church conflicts surfaced). After 1901, with the end of the Boxer Rebellion and the Boxer Indemnity events, external ethnic conflicts temporarily eased,

but internal power struggles within the church (between Italian, German, French, and Spanish clergy) rapidly emerged and intensified. This caused the church's development focus to shift from externally utilizing 'protective conversion' and 'dependent conversion' to internally competing for church power and coping with Sino-foreign ethnic conflicts. Therefore, the 1902 power shift opened a new stage of internal and external difficulties but with diversified functions.

Turning Point 5: 1933 (Intensification of Sino-foreign conflicts and beginning of localization). After the 1930s, Chinese nationalism and anti-imperialist patriotic movements surged. The Sino-foreign conflict, represented by the foreign bishop Pasini's exclusion of Chinese clergy, reached a boiling point. Until 1952, when foreign clergy were expelled and the Three-Self Reform Movement began, the era of foreign control ended. The beginning and end of this period (1933 to 1952) define the localization transition period of the church from 'foreigner-led' to 'Chinese-managed.'

In summary, Tongyuanfang's history can be divided into four stages. The periodization points are based not only on chronological order but also on fundamental turning points in church administrative status, architectural physical form, and social environmental strategies, enabling the research subject to be clearly embedded in the grand narrative of modern Chinese history and church history.

2.2. Historical Period Division

The historical evolution of Tongyuanfang is not a linear flow of time but the product of the interaction between modern Chinese social change, global Catholic expansion strategies, and local crises. Scientific periodization of Tongyuanfang's history aims to construct a structured analytical framework to reveal its internal mechanism of evolving from a secret missionary outpost (point) to a Northwest regional center (area), and finally back to a functional convent (entity). The underlying logic of its development lies in the church's sensitive capture and utilization of external 'power': through unequal treaties to gain administrative status (political power); through famine and war relief to gain numbers of believers (social power); through large-scale construction to achieve physical fortification (material power). Each historical stage turning point marks a fundamental adjustment of the church's survival and development strategies, thus closely linking Tongyuanfang's destiny curve with the pulse of modern Chinese history.

2.3.1. Stage One: Founding and Establishment of General Church Status (1711-1845)

The core of this stage lies in the church's underground survival capability during the anti-Christian period and the strategic considerations for the general church site selection, laying the foundation for Tongyuanfang's later status as the 'Northwest General Church.'

1. Missionary Foundation and the Twists and Turns of the Ming-Qing Transition

1) Early Foundation and Peak

Yuan Dynasty Introduction (1328): Catholic activities in Shaanxi can be traced back to the Yuan Dynasty. The Italian Franciscan friar Ricoldo da Monte di Croce, under the order of John of Montecorvino, the Bishop of Beijing, conducted missionary work in the Sanyuan and Gaoling areas of Shaanxi. According to historical records, believers at that time already numbered over a thousand [6].

Late Ming Revival (1630): German missionaries Johann Adam Schall von Bell and Giacomo Rho managed the Shaanxi-Gansu church affairs, actively operating in the Sanyuan, Fuping, and Gaoling areas. This period was the early peak of Catholicism in Shaanxi, with the total number of Christians once exceeding 20,000.

Renewed Sprouting: The Li Zicheng peasant uprising at the end of the Ming Dynasty severely damaged the church, and Christians were nearly scattered. Until 1668, descendants of Wei Liangdong, a Catholic from Fuping, and Kang, a Christian, moved to Liujiabao in Gaoling, guiding the Liu, Li, Wang, Lv, and Han clans to convert. The secret continuation of faith laid the foundation for the 320-year Catholic history in the Gaoling area. Later foreign missionaries renamed it 'Tongyuanfang,' meaning reaching far (to the Holy See and Heaven), endowing this place with profound religious symbolic significance.

2) 'Rites Controversy': From Strategic Success to Anti-Christian Outbreak

Strategic Success of the 'Matteo Ricci Rules': Early missionaries like Matteo Ricci adopted missionary strategies adapted to Chinese national conditions, not opposing Chinese traditional 'veneration' and 'ancestor worship' customs, and equating 'Lord of Heaven' with the 'God' revered by Confucianism. This strategy was praised by Kangxi as the 'Matteo Ricci

rules' and promoted the rapid spread of Catholicism in China. The number of Christians in Shaanxi once reached over 60,000.

Hundred Years of Anti-Christian Policy (starting 1704): Since 1669, as Franciscans and other orders insisted on opposing 'Confucian veneration' and 'ancestor worship' traditions, the 'Rites Controversy' intensified. In 1704, the Pope formally prohibited Chinese Christians from worshipping ancestors and Confucius, triggering strong backlash from the Kangxi Emperor. Emperor Kangxi subsequently decreed 'henceforth Westerners need not spread religion in China, prohibition is acceptable, to avoid causing trouble' [7], thus beginning the nearly two-hundred-year 'anti-Christian' period.

Deep-seated Contradiction: The 'Rites Controversy' was superficially a Sino-Western cultural conflict, but essentially the Roman Curia attempted to control the thoughts of Chinese Christians through church authority, which was viewed by the Qing government as interference with and challenge to its sovereignty. Qing emperors of successive generations strictly enforced anti-Christian policies, forcing Catholic activities underground and shifting missionary centers to remote areas, providing development opportunities for places like Gaoling far from political centers.

2. The Founding Work of Francesco de Fosco

1) The Founding of Tongyuanfang (1711): During the anti-Christian period, Bishop Francesco de Fosco of the Shaanxi-Jin Apostolic Vicariate (Italian Franciscan, became the second Apostolic Vicar of the Qin-Jin Vicariate in 1727) purchased land in Tongyuan in 1711 and built a seven-room brick-and-wood structure church, developing several hundred Christian families. This marked the formal beginning of Catholic propagation in Gaoling and was the first cornerstone for Tongyuanfang's future as the Northwest General Church.

Refuge and Sanctuary During Anti-Christian Period: Against the backdrop of increasingly severe anti-Christian policies during the Yongzheng reign, Bishop Fosco took refuge in the earthen cave dwellings of Zhanggegou in the Xiyuan parish of Weinan Diocese, Shaanxi, persisting in preaching and pastoral care and managing the Shaanxi-Shanxi church affairs for over twenty years.

Important Status: This refuge was later praised by subsequent bishops as the 'Mother of All Meeting Places' and 'Sanctuary of All Bishops,' highlighting its status as the spiritual core of the Northwest Diocese during the anti-Christian period. Bishop Fosco also presided over the

construction and expansion of the South Church in Xi'an (today's Five-Star Street Church), which was later called the 'General Church of Catholicism in Shaanxi.'

Memorial: Bishop Fosco passed away in Longjiagou in 1741. His remains were relocated to Gaoling Tongyuanfang Church in 1884. His tombstone is still in Tongyuanfang today, serving as physical evidence of the early church's persistence in faith during difficult times.

Bishop Francesco de Fosco (1679-1741) was an important figure in the history of Catholicism in Northwest China. Born into a noble family in Naples, Italy, he joined the Franciscan Order and was ordained in 1696, arriving in China in 1716. In 1727, he was appointed the second Apostolic Vicar of the Qin-Jin Apostolic Vicariate.

One of Bishop Fosco's most important contributions was presiding over the construction and expansion of the South Church in Xi'an (today's Five-Star Street Church). This church was later called the 'General Church of Catholicism in Shaanxi.' Its architecture fused Roman style with Chinese traditional characteristics and remains a key cultural relics protection unit in Shaanxi Province to this day.

In the context of increasingly severe anti-Christian policies during the Qing Yongzheng reign, Bishop Fosco demonstrated extraordinary courage and wisdom. He took refuge in the earthen cave dwellings of Zhanggegou in the Xiyuan parish of Weinan Diocese, Shaanxi, persisting in preaching and pastoral care and managing the Shaanxi-Shanxi church affairs for over twenty years. This refuge was later praised by subsequent bishops as the 'Mother of All Meeting Places' and 'Sanctuary of All Bishops.'

In 1741, Bishop Fosco was martyred in Longjiagou. He was initially buried in Zhanggegou and later relocated to Gaoling Tongyuanfang Church in 1884. He maintained and developed the Catholic communities in the Shaanxi-Shanxi region during difficult times, laying an important foundation for the spread of Catholicism in Northwest China. Today, his tombstone is still preserved in Gaoling Tongyuanfang Catholic Church for future generations to admire and commemorate.

2.3.2. Stage Two: Rapid Expansion, Fortification Formation, and Crisis Response (1845-1901)

The core logic of this stage is: Tongyuanfang utilized the social turmoil of the late Qing Dynasty and treaty privileges, transforming crises into opportunities for religious expansion. Through large-scale material investment and institutional construction, it completed the transformation from a secret missionary outpost to a fully functional 'Northwest General Church' physical fortress.

1. The Era of Bishop Vagnone (1849-1884): Opportunistic Expansion in Crisis

The 35-year tenure of Bishop Vagnone (Ephysius Chiaais, Italian) was a key turning point in Tongyuanfang's history.

1) Legal Protection and Property Recovery

Treaty Extension Effect: The signing of the 1860 Beijing Convention gave missionaries the legal privilege to 'rent and purchase land to build freely' in the interior. This was the fundamental prerequisite for the church's transition from 'semi-underground' to open physical expansion.

Asserting Rights: Bishop Vagnone used the treaty to actively recover church properties occupied by the Qing government. From 1861 to 1863, he negotiated multiple times with the Shaanxi Governor to demand the return of the South Church property in Xi'an. After the French Ambassador to China intervened, the Qing government finally issued an 'Imperial Edict' on August 15, 1866, and the provincial government returned 158 rooms of the South Church property and the Chenggu County city church. This process fully demonstrated the church's ability to pressure local governments through foreign powers.

2) Two Major Crises and the Deepening of 'Dependent on Church' and 'Eating from Church' Mechanisms

Bishop Vagnone cleverly transformed wars and famines into means of absorbing converts and expanding influence, forming a special 'crisis evangelization' model.

The Muslim Uprising (1862)

Security Guarantee: In 1862, the Muslim rebel army captured Gaoling, Sanyuan, and other places. Bishop Vagnone negotiated with the rebel leader, claiming 'we are all believers of the Lord,' thus reaching an agreement of mutual non-interference [10]. The two sides had close

contacts and harmonious relations. Therefore, 'the rebels not only did not harm the Christians but specially protected and helped them, even giving them gifts.' [11]

Unique Historical Fact: Historical records show that the rebels 'not only did not harm the Christians but specially protected and helped them, even giving them gifts.' At that time, when the government investigated household registration, it found that in Gaoling County, '4,028 households were extinguished, and 32,191 men and women died' [12], yet Tongyuanfang village alone remained safe. Other records state: 'In the first year of the Tongzhi reign, when the Muslim uprising occurred, many locals converted to Catholicism to survive. After generals Duoblong and Zuo Zongtang led troops to clear Guanzhong and Shaanxi, the Muslim rebels perished, and Catholicism flourished.' [13]

Expansion Logic (Dependent on Church): This 'safe island in chaotic times' effect attracted large numbers of non-Christians to 'depend on the church' and 'join the church' for survival. The number of Christians in the province thus surged to over 20,000, with believer growth based on survival rationality rather than pure faith.

Subsequent Impact: Even after the Muslim Uprising failed, many converts did not dare to leave the church for fear of future unrest, allowing the number of Christians to be maintained and continue growing.

The Great Shaanxi Famine (1878)

Disaster: In 1878 (the fourth year of the Guangxu reign), a great drought occurred in Shaanxi, with severe disaster, corpses everywhere, and large numbers of displaced refugees. Historical records state: 'In the summer of the third year of Guangxu, June saw heavy rain, with water three feet deep on flat ground, all crops destroyed, no harvest that autumn. From July there was no rain until June of the following year, no winter wheat, bare land for a hundred miles in summer, wheat at over two thousand cash per dou, over three thousand men and women died of starvation.' [14]

Famine Relief: Bishop Vagnone of the Shaanxi Apostolic Vicariate and Auxiliary Bishop Pagnucci vigorously engaged in famine relief, setting up relief stations in Tongyuanfang and other places, distributing money, grain, and clothing, building charitable hospitals, caring for the elderly and orphans, and providing seeds to restore production. The church's relief efforts alleviated local disaster conditions and temporarily eased church-state relations.

Expansion Logic (Eating from Church): Famine relief was also used as a tool for absorbing converts. Bishop Vagnone stipulated that non-Christians wishing to receive church grain must 'first swear to join the church, and after joining, cannot leave' [15]. This is the 'eating from church' phenomenon. The bishop directed Christians to gather starving refugees and organize them to build the great walls of Tongyuanfang, using the 'work relief' method for famine relief, enabling refugees to have food and work, achieving two goals at once. This strategy increased the number of Catholics in the Gaoling area to over 700. During this period, due to consecutive years of disaster and war, the local population of Gaoling decreased from over 50,000 in 1861 to less than 30,000 [16], yet Catholicism saw a large increase in converts during this time. It must be said that due to the masses' 'dependent on church' and 'eating from church' behaviors, this propagation method of Catholicism was an important reason for its rapid development during the late Qing and Republican periods.

Negative Evaluation: This practice of 'allowing anyone to join the church regardless of character' led to uneven quality among believers. Some 'migrants and those with old grudges against locals' even used their conversion status to compete and fight, damaging the church's social reputation.

Famine Relief Merit Stele (1879): In 1879 (the fifth year of Guangxu), Christians carved this event on a stone tablet to publicize the relief merits of missionaries Vagnone and Pagnucci. This stele was erected at Tongyuanfang Catholic Church in Gaoling County but is now lost. According to the transcription preserved in Gaoling County Cultural Center:

'Respectfully Presenting the Merit Stele for the High (Lin) Bishop, Head of the Shaanxi Mission and Supervisor of Xinjiang and Other Areas'

It is said: Heaven has the virtue of loving life, and gentlemen have hearts of loving others. Could it be that religion, without the virtue of benevolence in heart, would have long-lasting thoughts of relief? Examining the foreign missionaries who came to China for over fifteen years, with advanced age over seventy, living simply but never stingy with relief. In personal conduct, no small details were neglected; in actions, the great principles were respected. Humility was often shown in receiving people, and gentleness was even more evident in teaching. In chaotic times, they saved thousands of Christian lives; in famine years, they generously distributed wealth to help the masses. Other relief activities included managing grain stations, rescuing the good from evil, distributing good seeds, assisting with repairs, combining medicines to help people, caring for the elderly, and providing burial implements,

all based on the heart of not bearing to see people suffer, practicing the way of not bearing to see people suffer. To restore the faith of believers, they did even more. They distributed grain daily and gave money for rituals. In deep winter, they distributed cotton clothes to ward off the cold. Extending the heart of loving others, they viewed the world as one family and fellow Christians as brothers. They felt others' hunger as their own hunger and others' drowning as their own drowning. How profound was this benevolence! It was appropriate that neighbors and fellow villagers, hearing their teachings, were joyfully transformed. In cities and counties, those who admired their reputation generally wished to return. The population admired but had no way to express it, wanting to praise but unable to do so, so they jointly erected this stele to express their virtue.'

This stele text detailedly records the relief actions of the bishop and auxiliary bishop of Tongyuanfang during this drought. It can be seen that during the great disaster, the Franciscan missionaries intensified their evangelization activities and vigorously developed converts. When Bishop Fosco was appointed in 1845, Shaanxi had about 13,000 Christians, which reached 25,000 by 1878, nearly doubling. [17]

3) Solidification of Material Fortress and Talent Training System

Construction of the Great Cathedral: In 1875, Bishop Vagnone and Auxiliary Bishop Pagnucci expanded the original seven-room cathedral into a 14-room brick-and-wood structure, Sino-Western combined great cathedral.

Scale Verification: The new cathedral was 46 meters long and 14 meters wide, covering an area of 1,166 square meters. The main body adopted Gothic style and could accommodate 2,000 worshippers simultaneously. It was the largest Catholic church in the Northwest at that time, marking the complete establishment of Tongyuanfang's material foundation as the 'Northwest General Church.'

Wall Defense System: During the 1878 famine, the church adopted the 'work relief' method, gathering refugees to build the Tongyuanfang walls. This measure not only relieved the refugees but also endowed Tongyuanfang with a solid physical fortress form, enabling it to protect itself in turbulent times.

Continuous Talent Supply: The expanded seminary continued to train about 12 Chinese missionaries, who were active in various counties of Guanzhong (Sanyuan, Zhouzhi, Huxian,

etc.) and even as far as Shanxi and Gansu, becoming the backbone of the church's influence radiating throughout the Northwest.

2.3.3. Stage Three: Surface of Church Power Disputes and Transfer of Administrative Center Status (1902-1932)

This stage delves into the roots of internal conflicts, the extension of church functions, and the final transfer of the administrative center. Tongyuanfang rapidly declined from its peak influence and ultimately completed its functional transformation.

1. 'Imperialist Power Play' and Power Struggles Within the Church

After Bishop Pagnucci's death, long-hidden conflicts within the Tongyuanfang church intensified due to issues of the successor's nationality and style, reflecting the power struggle among Franciscans of different nationalities.

1) The Death of Bishop Herix and the Power Struggle Between Germany and Italy (1901-1905)

Power Vacuum and Competition: After Pagnucci (Italian) passed away, the position of bishop of the Shaanxi-Gansu Apostolic Vicariate became the focus. Herix (Italian) was appointed by the Roman Curia, but it was rumored that his appointment letter was intercepted by German Franciscan missionaries en route back to Shaanxi. This incident was not only symbolic of power struggles but also reflected the fierce competition between different national orders (especially Italian and German) for leadership of the Northwest Diocese.

Sudden Death: Herix ultimately died in Taiyuan, Shanxi in 1905. His cause of death sparked much speculation within the church, further illustrating the sharpness and complexity of internal conflicts in the diocese at that time.

2) The Era of Bishop Giesen: Luxury, Tyranny, and Relocation Attempts (1905-1908)

German Bishop's Tyranny: Giesen (German), with financial support from relatives and fundraising from Europe and America, had abundant finances and lived luxuriously. However, he 'relied on wealth and power to oppress the people' and implemented brutal management within the church, arousing strong resistance from some Christians.

Relocation Attempt and Regional Meeting: Giesen once planned to relocate the bishop's residence from remote Tongyuanfang to the provincial capital Xi'an South Church to gain greater political influence, but this was not realized due to wartime chaos. However, the North China Provincial Franciscan Bishops' Conference (1908) held during his tenure once again proved Tongyuanfang's status as a regional religious conference center at that time.

3) The Era of Bishop Mouly: Internal and External Difficulties and Resignation (1908-1916)

Internal Exclusion: After Mouly (French) took office, internal church conflicts did not subside. He implemented exclusion policies, causing the dominance of Italian clergy to collapse and forming opposition with Spanish clergy.

Tyranny During the Xinhai Revolution: During the Xinhai Revolution (1911), Mouly's attitude was overbearing when handling the Weinan Church case, even attempting to request French military intervention, arousing strong dissatisfaction from both inside and outside the church.

Finance and Resignation: Due to escalating internal conflicts and financial difficulties, Mouly ultimately resigned under pressure from the Roman Curia. This reflected the high centralization of local church power and the Roman Congregation for the Evangelization of Peoples' ability to check and balance local bishops.

2. Extension of Church Functions and Spread of Western Technology

Against the backdrop of warlord 混战 and internal and external troubles, the church was no longer just a religious center; its functions began to penetrate into social and technological fields.

1) The Era of Bishop Massi: Shelter During Warlord Mixing and Localization of Organizations (1916-1928)

Shelter Again in Crisis: Massi (Italian) was appointed to quell internal disputes. During the 1926 Liu Zhenhua siege, Tongyuanfang once again became an important shelter. This time, the shelter was not limited to Christians but even included social elites such as the wife of Guo Jian, commander of the Jingguo Army, demonstrating the church's social shelter function beyond religion.

Localization of Religious Organizations: In 1923, Massi, cooperating with Spanish priests, founded the 'Franciscan Third Order Sisters of the Sacred Heart' (commonly known as the 'Black Order') composed of Chinese nuns. This was an important symbol of the beginning of church organization localization, providing a formal platform for training Chinese clergy and nuns.

2) The Era of Bishop Tissot de Chardins: Introduction of Technology and Educational Transformation (1928-1932)

Spread of Western Technology: Tissot de Chardins (Italian) was proficient in electricity and mechanics. His tenure was the peak of Western technology import to Tongyuanfang. He installed the earliest Western technology facilities in Gaoling County: automatic generators, electric lights, and wireless radio stations. He also set up a seismograph and a meteorological observatory, making Tongyuanfang one of the technology centers in the Northwest at that time.

Educational Content Innovation: Tissot de Chardins included Western scientific knowledge such as mathematics and physics in the seminarian curriculum, objectively promoting the spread of Western science in the Northwest region.

3. Final Transfer of Administrative Center and Functional Transformation (1932)

Preparation for Transfer: To adapt to the changing times and church development needs, Tissot de Chardins gradually transferred the actual administrative work of the general church to the South Church in the provincial capital Xi'an, preparing for the final transfer of the administrative center.

Diocese Division and End of Tongyuanfang's Status: In 1932, the Vatican divided the Guanzhong Diocese into five independent dioceses (Xi'an, Sanyuan, Zhouzhi, Dali, and Fengxiang). The Gaoling area was placed under the Sanyuan Diocese, with the new diocese's general church located in Sanyuan County town.

Status Transformation: This administrative division marked the complete end of Tongyuanfang's history as the administrative center of Catholicism in the Northwest. It was downgraded and transformed from a regional administrative center to a Franciscan functional convent, mainly undertaking functions such as monastic life, education, and charity.

2.3.4. Functional Convent Era and Localization Transition (1933-1952)

1. Diocese Redivision and Formation of Functional Convent

1) Complete Transfer of Diocese Administration (1932)

Division Background: With the continuous development and management complexity of the church, during the tenure of Bishop Massi and Bishop Tissot de Chardins, there was already intention to divide the original Guanzhong Diocese.

Final Configuration: In 1932, the Vatican's Congregation for the Evangelization of Peoples finally divided the Xi'an Archdiocese into five independent dioceses: Xi'an, Sanyuan, Zhouzhi, Dali, and Fengxiang. The Gaoling area was placed under the jurisdiction of the Sanyuan Diocese, within the missionary scope of the Italian Venice Franciscans, with the bishop's residence located in Sanyuan County town.

Transformation of Tongyuanfang: This division marked that Tongyuanfang completely lost its status as the administrative center of Catholicism in the Northwest, officially transforming into a Franciscan functional convent, mainly retaining functions of education (seminary), charity, and religious activities.

2) Appointment of Bishop Pasini and Ignition of Ethnic Conflicts

New Bishop Arrival: In 1932, the Italian Franciscan Bishop Fulgentius Pasini was formally appointed by the Roman Curia as the first Apostolic Prefect of the Sanyuan Diocese.

Ignition of Ethnic Conflicts: Pasini always despised China, openly claiming that 'China is barbaric.' This colonial mentality formed fierce conflict with the surging anti-imperialist patriotic movement across the country, directly leading to the rapid intensification of Sino-foreign conflicts in the Gaoling area.

2. Monopoly of Church Power and Intensification of Sino-Foreign Conflicts

Against the backdrop of awakening national consciousness, the high monopoly of church power by foreign clergy became the main focus of conflict during this period.

1) Student Resistance Movements in the Seminary

Root of Conflict: The conflict concentrated between foreign missionaries and Chinese students, essentially a struggle against oppression and for national self-determination. As

early as the Tissot de Chardins period, he expressed support for Pasini's exclusion of Chinese clergy.

Intensification of 'Foolish People's Education': Pasini was appointed seminary rector by Tissot de Chardins in 1928. During his teaching, 'he often imposed oppression and foolish people's education on Chinese youth students, delighting in their flattery and fawning obedience to imperialism.'

Two Large-scale Protests: 1928: Students launched the first large-scale resistance movement, 'over ten people voluntarily withdrew from the seminary,' forcing Tissot de Chardins to remove Pasini from the rector position. 1930: Tissot de Chardins reappointed Pasini as rector, boosting his arrogance. Pasini also recommended Camand, who held the same anti-China ideology, to head the minor seminary. Camand expelled over thirty patriotic students immediately after taking office, openly claiming 'without you, we have plenty of people.' This action again provoked students to launch the second large-scale resistance movement in 1930, reflecting the strong awakening of Chinese youth's national consciousness.

2) Church Power Monopoly Under 'Episcopacy'

Exclusion of Local Forces: After Pasini took office as Apostolic Prefect of Sanyuan, to strengthen foreign control over the diocese, he adopted extreme exclusion policies, 'banishing' all Chinese clergy to remote areas, assigning all better territories and more important positions to foreign priests.

Vatican's Intent: The Roman Curia implemented 'Episcopacy,' aiming to formally grant Chinese dioceses independent status, but in reality, by appointing numerous foreign bishops to hold real power in various dioceses, to firmly control the power of Chinese dioceses. 1936 survey data showed that foreign clergy (6) at Tongyuan Catholic Church far outnumbered Chinese clergy (3), with church power highly concentrated in foreign hands. Among more than 20 archdioceses nationwide, only 3 Chinese served as archbishops, and among more than 100 dioceses, only over 20 Chinese served as bishops. This was an unprecedented phenomenon of church power foreignization in church history.

3) Strong Material Foundation and Scale of Charity

Property Scale (1936): Although the administrative center had been transferred, Tongyuanfang as a convent still possessed a strong material foundation, which was the

guarantee of its continued influence. Building assets: owned 3 large buildings, totaling 342 rooms; Land assets: owned 195 mu of land.

Charitable Enterprises: The church continued to operate orphanages, nursing homes, hospitals, Guanghua School, and other charitable and educational enterprises. Annual expenses were about 9,500 silver dollars (temporarily supplied by the church), demonstrating its continuous social service capacity and fundraising channels.

3. Major Contributions to Local Economy and End of Localization

1) Support for Jinghui Canal Restoration Project

Historical Background: In the late Qing and early Republic, frequent droughts occurred in Guanzhong, and the people urgently needed to rebuild large-scale water conservancy projects. The famous water conservancy scientist Li Yizhi, returning from studying in Germany twice, was committed to restoring the Yin Jing Project (predecessor of the Zhengguo Canal).

Key Donation: Against the backdrop of warlord mixing, national poverty, and people's hardship, causing severe shortage of project funds (the gap exceeding more than half of the total), the Shaanxi Catholic Church extended a helping hand, providing crucial financial support.

Important Promoter: This donation, combined with contributions from the Hua-Yang Famine Relief Association (a Catholic institution contacted by Tongyuan Catholic Church) and overseas Chinese, ultimately facilitated the completion of the Jinghui Canal, a large-scale water conservancy project 'benefiting the contemporary era and future generations,' making significant contributions to agricultural development and post-disaster reconstruction in the Guanzhong Plain. This was a model of the Catholic Church's deep involvement in local economic construction.

2) Complete Localization of the Chinese Church (1952)

Departure of Foreigners: In 1952, with the fundamental change in China's political environment, foreign clergy such as Pasini were expelled. This completely ended the over 300-year history (counting from the late Ming) of foreign control over Catholic affairs in Gaoling and even the Northwest.

'Three-Self Reform': In the same year, the Tongyuanfang Three-Self Reform Movement Preparatory Committee was established, carrying out reforms to local religion.

Final Outcome: Church management and leadership were formally assumed by Chinese clergy—Chinese church affairs managed by Chinese themselves (localization).

2.4 Reasons for the Localized Integration of Tongyuanfang Catholicism

Tongyuanfang Catholic Church is the epitome of Catholicism taking root, developing, and transforming in Shaanxi and even the entire Northwest region. It is not just a church but a faith and cultural center of over three hundred years. Its history vividly illustrates how Catholicism was accepted by local people in the cracks of natural and man-made disasters and ultimately integrated into the local culture, passed down to this day. The history of Tongyuanfang Catholic Church began with the pioneering of Franciscan missionaries. The reason it could develop from a small missionary outpost to the general church of the Shaanxi and even Northwest Diocese, and stand firm through vicissitudes, is precisely the microcosm of the macro history of Catholicism's spread in China. Its process is closely intertwined with several major historical events in modern Shaanxi.

1. Tongyuanfang Catholic Church: A Shelter in Chaotic Times

1) Survival and Protection: 'Noah's Ark' in Natural and Man-made Disasters

First, 'Eating from Church' and Material Relief in Famines: Tongyuanfang Church was not an isolated religious building. Through purchasing land, it gradually developed into a self-sufficient community with large amounts of farmland, orchards, and livestock, forming social and insurance networks with the outside world. This economic foundation made it a crucial relief center during Shaanxi's frequent famines. For example, during the 'Ding-Wu Extraordinary Famine' (1877-1878) that swept northern China in the early Guangxu years of the Qing Dynasty, Shaanxi suffered terribly, with corpses everywhere. Tongyuanfang Church, with its stable material reserves, opened porridge factories and conducted large-scale famine relief. Historical records show that the church at that time 'adopted several hundred starving people' and used this opportunity to develop a large number of converts. For disaster victims on the brink of death, converting 'for bread' was the most direct survival rationality. This helping hand at the critical moment established the most primitive and solid mass foundation

for Catholicism. The history of many Christian families can be traced back to this great famine.

Second, 'Dependent on Church' and Military Fortification in Wars: The 'protector' role of Tongyuanfang Church was even more extreme during wars. To cope with the Shaanxi Muslim Uprising (1862-1873) during the Tongzhi years of the Qing Dynasty, when social order completely collapsed, all parties fought, and human life was worthless, Tongyuanfang Church built tall and sturdy walls, moats, and equipped itself with self-defense weapons, evolving from a religious venue into a fortified military fortress that was easy to defend but difficult to attack. In the flames of war, this was not only the religious center for Christians but also a physical refuge for them and their relatives to escape the calamity. Its 'castle' image was deeply rooted in people's hearts.

Finally, this shelter function continued into the Republican era. In 1926, when warlord Liu Zhenhua besieged Xi'an, known as 'Two Tigers Defending Chang'an,' the surrounding areas of Xi'an were devastated. Relatively stable Tongyuanfang Church once again became a regional safe island, attracting a large number of refugees seeking shelter. The security provided by the church formed a sharp contrast with the turbulent society outside, making 'dependent on church'—that is, relying on church power to preserve life—a rational choice for many people.

2. Spirit and Society: Building a Faith Community Beyond Kinship

1) From Temporary Relief to Permanent Community: The practice of Tongyuanfang Church was that it did not stop at temporary charity. Around the church, it constructed a complete community system, successively building a seminary, convent, Latin school (minor seminary), printing house, clinic, orphanage, and schools for both sexes. This meant that from birth, education, work, participation in spiritual life to old age, a believer's entire life course could be supported within this system. This all-around, full life-cycle community service, when the traditional kinship system was weakened by war and famine, provided a new, powerful social bond and sense of belonging, making 'Christian' identity a community identity transcending blood ties.

2) Elite Training and Internalization of Faith: Tongyuanfang's Latin school (minor seminary) was the core of the localization strategy. It freely enrolled Christian children, teaching not only theology and Latin but also Chinese, mathematics, and other knowledge. Here, the

earliest batch of local clergy in Shaanxi was trained. These local priests were different from foreign missionaries; they were rooted in local culture and understood the thinking habits and emotional needs of the villagers. Their existence and leadership gradually stripped Catholicism of its pure 'foreign religion' color, giving it a 'face of our own people.' Through them, faith could be spread in ways closer to local culture, thus gradually evolving from the older generation's 'selective acceptance' out of utilitarianism to the younger generation's 'hereditary faith' at the spiritual level.

3) Influenced by parents' religious belief, children also believe in Christianity from childhood, which is also a reason for farmers' conversion. Many believers grew up hearing their parents tell Bible stories and sing hymns, influenced by the religious atmosphere. When they grew up, they naturally believed in Christianity. The current Bishop Yu of Hanzhong Catholic Church told about his growth: when he was young, both ancestors and parents believed in Christianity. In Shaheying Village, Chenggu County, two to three hundred people all believed in Christianity. When he grew up, he naturally converted. Ms. Jia, current deputy director of the Hanzhong Three-Self Patriotic Movement Committee, also mentioned in 1930 that she converted at age 7 because her parents believed in Christianity, and most of her peers at that time were influenced by their parents to join the church.

4) Before the spread of Catholicism to Gaoling, there had always been a small number of religious activities locally, including Taoism, Buddhism, and Islam. Among them, Taoism and Buddhism, as indigenous religions, had been practiced for a relatively long time, but by the late Qing and Republican periods, they gradually declined. By a certain year, the entire county had only 5 Taoist priests and 7 Taoist nuns, most of whom wandered far away without fixed residences. As for Buddhism, in 1928, the entire county had only 272 believers. As for Islam, after the Muslim Uprising in a certain year, all Muslims in the county left home and moved west, and Islam disappeared from this place [26]. The singularity of local religious belief and the gradual decline of other religions provided a good external environment for Catholicism to establish itself and develop later.

3. Integration and Continuation: From Historical Witness to Cultural Heritage

1) Adaptive Integration of Architecture and Culture: The architecture of Tongyuanfang Church itself is a witness to Sino-Western fusion. Although its main body is Romanesque style, in decorative details, brick carving craftsmanship, and building material selection, local

elements are integrated. This material fusion is the intuitive manifestation of its efforts to embed itself in local cultural fabric.

2) Unyielding Faith Through Calamities: The history of Tongyuanfang Church runs through the late Qing's 'anti-missionary movements,' Republican warlord mixing, and later social changes. It repeatedly suffered calamities but was repeatedly rebuilt and revived, fully proving that after the initial utilitarian attachment, its faith community had formed strong internal cohesion and transmission resilience. When the historical backgrounds of 'eating from church' and 'dependent on church' gradually faded, faith itself, through family memory, community life, and spiritual sustenance, had become deeply rooted in people's daily lives.

3) Contemporary Transformation and Rebuilding as a Cultural Landmark: Today, the restored Tongyuanfang Catholic Church is not only an important Catholic activity center in Shaanxi but, due to its long history and unique architecture, is recognized as an important cultural heritage. It is no longer an isolated 'fortress' with colonial traces but has transformed into part of the local historical narrative and an important cultural resource. For believers, it is a sacred place of faith; for the local community and society, it is a witness to history. This dual identity of living faith and static heritage is the key to its ability to transcend eras and be passed down to this day.

In conclusion, the case of Tongyuanfang Catholic Church proves that the acceptance and localization of Catholicism in Shaanxi is a process deeply interacting with specific historical disasters such as the Ding-Wu Extraordinary Famine, the Muslim Uprising, and the Liu Zhenhua Siege. It began with survival-driven 'eating from church' and security-driven 'dependent on church,' and through constructing a fully functional faith community system and training local clergy elites, achieved a profound transformation from foreign to local. It not only provided shelter for people in chaotic times materially but also built a new home spiritually and socially. Ultimately, it successfully transformed itself from a 'Western fortress' branded by its era into a lasting existence deeply embedded in the Shaanxi local fabric, with both living faith function and static heritage value. The story of Tongyuanfang is an indispensable vivid footnote for understanding the course of Catholicism in China, especially in the Northwest region.